

ILOVEYOU

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The **ILOVEYOU** worm, also known as **VBS/Loveletter** and **Love Bug worm**, is a computer worm written in VBScript.

The virus arrived in e-mail boxes on May 4, 2000, with the simple subject of "ILOVEYOU" and an attachment "LOVE-LETTER-FOR-YOU.TXT.vbs". It spread across the world in just one day (traveling westward from Hong-Kong to Europe to the United States as workers arrived at their offices), infecting 10 percent of all computers connected to the Internet and causing about \$5.5 billion in damage. Most of the "damage" was the labor of getting rid of the virus. The worm was responsible for a denial-of-service attack on the official White House website. The Pentagon, CIA, and the British Parliament had to shut down their e-mail systems to get rid of the virus, as did most large corporations. On the whole, this particular malware caused widespread outrage, making it the most damaging virus ever. The virus overwrote important files, as well as music, multimedia and more, with a copy of itself. It also sent the virus to everyone on a user's contact list. Because it was written in Visual Basic Script, this particular virus only affected computers running the Microsoft Windows operating system.

Two aspects of the worm made it effective:

- It exploited the weakness of the e-mail system design that an attached program could be run easily by simply opening the attachment; the underlying mechanism – VBScript – had not been exploited to such a degree previously to direct attention to its potential, thus the necessary layers of protection were not in place.
- It used the right psychological button to entice users to open the e-mail and ensure its continued propagation. The prospect of love is a powerful motivation.



Because the virus used mailing lists as its source of targets, the messages often appeared to come from an acquaintance and so might be considered "safe", providing further incentive to open them. All it took was a few users at each site to access the VBS attachment to generate the thousands and thousands of e-mails that would cripple e-mail systems under their weight, not to mention overwrite thousands of files on workstations and accessible servers.

Variants of the worm:

1. Attachment: LOVE-LETTER-FOR-YOU.TXT.vbs Subject Line: ILOVEYOU
Message Body: kindly check the attached LOVELETTER coming from me.
2. Attachment: Very Funny.vbs Subject Line: fwd: Joke Message Body: empty.
3. Attachment: mothersday.vbs Subject Line: Mother's Day Order Confirmation
Message Body: We have proceeded to charge your credit card for the amount of \$326.92 for the Mother's Day diamond special. We have attached a detailed invoice to this e-mail. Please print out the attachment and keep it in a safe place. Thanks Again and Have a Happy Mother's Day! mothersday@subdimension.com
4. Attachment: virus_warning.jpg.vbs Subject Line: Dangerous Virus Warning
Message Body: There is a dangerous virus circulating. Please click attached picture to view it and learn to avoid it.
5. Attachment: Important.TXT.vbs Subject Line: Important! Read carefully!!
Message Body: Check the attached IMPORTANT coming from me!
6. Attachment: Virus-Protection-Instructions.vbs Subject Line: How to protect yourself from the ILOVEYOU bug!
Message Body: Here's the easy way to fix the love virus.
7. Attachment: KillEmAll.TXT.VBS Subject Line: I Cant Believe This!!!
Message Body: I Can't Believe I Have Just Recieved[sic] This Hate E-mail. Take A Look!
8. Attachment: ArabAir.TXT.vbs Subject Line: Thank You For Flying With Arab Airlines
Message Body: Please, check if the bill is correct by opening the attached file.

Legislative aftermath. The alleged author of the virus Reomel Lamoires from Manila, Philippines was briefly held in May 2000 in connection with the virus outbreak. He denied writing the virus, later he claimed the release of the code had been accidental. As there were no laws in the Philippines against virus-writing at the time, he was soon released.